

THE LOUISIANA FLOOD INSURANCE GUIDE

Everything You Should Know Before
The Next Storm Hits

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A Note From Brian

I have spent years sitting across kitchen tables from Louisiana families after they lost everything to floodwater. Most of them said the same thing: *I never thought it could happen here.*

I wrote this guide because I am tired of watching good people get blindsided by something that was preventable. Flood insurance is not complicated, but the industry makes it confusing on purpose. This guide cuts through that.

Read it. Share it with your neighbors. Use it to ask better questions of whoever your insurance agent happens to be — even if that is not me. The point is to make sure you do not end up like the families I have had to deliver bad news to.

If you have questions after reading this, my number is on every page. I answer personally.

— Brian Hall

What This Guide Covers

1. The Hard Truth About Homeowners Insurance and Floods
2. What 2016 Taught Louisiana (And Why Most People Forgot)
3. The 30-Day Waiting Period — And Why It Matters Right Now
4. What Flood Insurance Actually Covers (and Doesn't)
5. NFIP vs Private Flood Insurance
6. The 5 Mistakes That Cost Louisiana Homeowners Thousands
7. How to Read Your Declarations Page
8. After a Flood: The First 48 Hours
9. Quick Reference — Your Parish at a Glance
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1. The Hard Truth About Homeowners Insurance and Floods

Here is the single most important sentence in this guide:

Your homeowners insurance does NOT cover flood damage. Not a dime of it.

I cannot tell you how many people I have met who did not know this until they were standing in three feet of water in their own living room. They called their insurance company expecting help. The insurance company told them flood damage is excluded.

Standard homeowners insurance covers what happens INSIDE your house — a burst pipe, a roof leak, a fire. The moment water comes from OUTSIDE — rising creeks, storm surge, heavy rainfall pooling on your foundation — it becomes a flood. Floods are excluded from every standard homeowners policy in America.

Why This Matters

The average flood claim payout in Louisiana is \$63,691. That is what your homeowners insurance will NOT pay if your home floods. That is what comes out of your pocket — or off your savings, or onto a 30-year SBA disaster loan.

Flood insurance is a separate policy. It only takes care of flood damage. It is the only thing that will write you a check after a flood.

2. What 2016 Taught Louisiana (And Why Most People Forgot)

On August 12, 2016, a no-name storm dropped 31 inches of rain over the Florida Parishes in three days. By the time it stopped, 146,000 homes were damaged. Total losses topped \$15 billion.

Here is the part most people would rather forget:

About 75% of homes that flooded in Livingston Parish had never flooded before. Most of them were in Zone X — the so-called "low risk" zone. Most had no flood insurance because their lender did not require it.

Those families lost everything. Many are still paying off SBA disaster loans almost ten years later. Some never rebuilt at all.

Here is the lesson: **flood zones tell you what your lender requires. They do not tell you what is actually going to happen.** About 25% of all flood claims in America come from properties OUTSIDE high-risk zones.

If you live in Louisiana and you do not have flood insurance because someone told you that you do not need it — you are gambling with everything you own.

Hurricane Ida (2021)

Cat 4 hurricane, 150 mph winds, made landfall in Lafourche Parish on August 29, 2021 — the 16th anniversary of Katrina. Storm surge overtopped the Larose levee. LaPlace got flooded because its levee project was not finished. A million people lost power.

Hurricane Laura (2020)

Strongest hurricane to hit Louisiana since 1856. Cameron Parish was nearly wiped out. Lake Charles took catastrophic damage. Six weeks later, Hurricane Delta hit the same area.

3. The 30-Day Waiting Period — And Why It Matters Right Now

When you buy a new flood insurance policy, there is a 30-day waiting period before it kicks in. This rule exists because, decades ago, people would call their agent the day a hurricane formed in the Gulf and try to buy a policy. The waiting period stops that.

Translation: if a storm is forming today, it is too late to buy flood insurance for that storm.

This is the single most important reason to buy flood insurance BEFORE you think you need it. Hurricane season runs June 1 through November 30. That means by May 1, you should already have a policy in place if you want to be covered for the start of the season.

Exceptions to the 30-Day Wait

Mortgage closing: If you are buying a home and your lender requires flood insurance, the policy can take effect at closing.

Newly mapped: If FEMA recently remapped your property into a higher-risk zone, the wait can be reduced.

Private flood insurance: Some private flood policies have shorter waiting periods of 10 to 15 days.

4. What Flood Insurance Covers (And Doesn't)

Flood insurance through the National Flood Insurance Program (NFIP) covers two things, sold as separate coverages:

Building Coverage (up to \$250,000)

- Foundation, walls, roof, anchorage system
- Electrical and plumbing systems
- Central air conditioning, furnace, water heater
- Built-in appliances (refrigerator, stove, dishwasher)
- Permanently installed cabinets, paneling, bookcases
- Permanently installed flooring (carpet, tile, wood)
- Detached garages (limited)
- Fuel and water tanks, well water tanks and pumps

Contents Coverage (up to \$100,000)

- Furniture and personal belongings
- Clothing and electronics
- Curtains and window treatments
- Portable appliances (washer, dryer, microwave)
- Valuable items (limited — discuss with your agent)

What Flood Insurance Does NOT Cover

This is the part that catches people off guard:

- Your vehicles (that is auto insurance)
- Temporary housing or living expenses while you cannot live in your home
- Lost income from a flooded business
- Most finished basement contents (drywall, carpet, furniture below grade)
- Pools, decks, fences, landscaping, sheds
- Wind damage (that is your homeowners policy or windstorm policy)
- Mold damage that occurred more than 30 days before the flood

5. NFIP vs Private Flood Insurance

Until recently, your only choice was the federal government's National Flood Insurance Program (NFIP). Now, private flood insurance has become a real option in Louisiana — and sometimes a much better one.

	NFIP (Federal)	Private Flood
Building Limit	\$250,000 max	Often \$1M+
Contents Limit	\$100,000 max	Often higher
Waiting Period	30 days	10-15 days typical
Rate Stability	Set by FEMA	Set by carrier
Available For	Most properties	Not all properties qualify
Replacement Cost	Limited	Often included
Loss of Use	Not covered	Sometimes covered

Which Should You Choose?

It depends on your property and your situation. After Risk Rating 2.0 rolled out in 2021-2023, NFIP rates went up significantly for many Louisiana properties. Private flood insurance has gotten cheaper as more carriers entered the market. For some homes, private is now hundreds of dollars cheaper per year. For others, NFIP is still the better deal.

The only way to know is to compare both. Any decent agent should run both options for you.

6. The 5 Mistakes That Cost Louisiana Homeowners Thousands

Mistake #1: Assuming homeowners insurance covers flooding

It does not. Period. If you have not bought flood insurance, you have no flood coverage. Confirm this in writing with your current insurer if you are unsure.

Mistake #2: Trusting that you are "low risk"

Zone X is not Zone Safe. About 25% of flood claims come from low-risk zones. In 2016, most of the flooded homes in Livingston Parish were Zone X. A Preferred Risk Policy in Zone X often costs less than \$50/month.

Mistake #3: Letting your policy lapse

If you let your flood insurance lapse — even by one day — the 30-day waiting period kicks back in when you reinstate. If a flood happens during that gap, you have no coverage. Set up auto-pay.

Mistake #4: Underinsuring your home

NFIP caps out at \$250,000 for buildings. If your home is worth more than that, you need excess flood insurance. Many high-value Louisiana homes are dramatically underinsured because no one ever explained this to the homeowner.

Mistake #5: Not getting an elevation certificate

If your home sits higher than the Base Flood Elevation, an elevation certificate can save you hundreds of dollars per year on your premium. The certificate costs \$300-\$600 once and pays for itself many times over.

7. How to Read Your Declarations Page

Your declarations page (or "dec page") is the cover sheet of your insurance policy. It summarizes what you have. Here is what to look for:

Policy Period: When your coverage starts and ends. If your renewal is approaching, that is when to shop alternatives.

Insured Property Address: Confirm this is correct. A wrong address can void your coverage.

Building Coverage Limit: Should reflect what it would cost to rebuild your home, up to NFIP's \$250K cap.

Contents Coverage Limit: Up to \$100K under NFIP. Take a phone-video walkthrough of every room — that is your inventory.

Deductibles: Higher deductibles = lower premiums. But you pay that out of pocket before insurance kicks in.

Flood Zone: Listed somewhere on the dec page. If it says X, you may qualify for Preferred Risk pricing.

Annual Premium: What you actually pay. Compare to other carriers every year or two — rates change.

If you cannot find any of these or they confuse you, send a photo of your dec page to Brian at bhall@sfbic.com. Free review. No obligation.

8. After a Flood: The First 48 Hours

Hour 0-2: Document Everything

Before you touch anything, before you start cleaning, take photos and video of EVERY room from EVERY angle. Open every drawer and closet. Walk through with your phone recording. This is the single most important thing you can do for your claim.

Hour 2-6: Notify Your Insurance Company

Call your flood insurance carrier and report the loss. Get a claim number. Write it down. They will assign an adjuster. The adjuster will call you within 24-72 hours depending on the volume of claims.

Hour 6-24: Stop the Bleeding

Make reasonable temporary repairs to prevent further damage — tarp the roof, board broken windows, get water out of the house if safe. Save every receipt. Insurance will reimburse reasonable mitigation expenses.

Day 2: Start Your Inventory

List everything that was damaged. Estimate value. Find receipts where you can. Photograph every damaged item. Create a spreadsheet if you can. The more organized you are, the more your adjuster will pay out.

What NOT to Do

- Do not throw anything away until your adjuster has documented it
- Do not sign any restoration contracts before your adjuster sees the damage
- Do not accept the first offer if it feels low — you can negotiate
- Do not use disaster funds (FEMA grants) for things insurance should pay — that hurts your case

9. Quick Reference — Your Parish at a Glance

Louisiana has 64 parishes. Here is a high-level look at flood risk profiles for many of them. Premiums shown are statewide averages — your actual rate depends on your specific property, zone, and coverage amount.

Parish	Risk Level	Notes
Acadia	Moderate	Flat farmland, easy flooding
Allen	Moderate	River and creek flooding
Ascension	Moderate-High	Amite River basin, hit in 2016
Assumption	High	Bayou and surge risk
Avoyelles	Moderate	Red and Atchafalaya rivers
Beauregard	Moderate	Calcasieu River basin
Bienville	Low-Moderate	Inland, river risk
Bossier	Moderate	Red River flooding
Caddo	Moderate	Red River flooding
Calcasieu	High	Hit hard by Laura/Delta 2020
Caldwell	Moderate	Ouachita River basin
Cameron	Very High	Coastal, wiped out by Laura
Catahoula	Moderate	Multiple river basins
Claiborne	Low-Moderate	Inland, lake/creek risk
Concordia	Moderate-High	Mississippi River basin
DeSoto	Low-Moderate	Inland, creek flooding
East Baton Rouge	Moderate-High	Hit hard in 2016, ~\$655/yr avg
East Carroll	Moderate	Mississippi River
East Feliciana	Moderate	River and creek flooding
Evangeline	Moderate	Bayou risk
Franklin	Moderate	Boeuf River basin
Grant	Low-Moderate	River risk
Iberia	Moderate-High	Atchafalaya basin, surge
Iberville	High	River and basin flooding
Jackson	Low-Moderate	Inland
Jefferson	High	Levee-protected but variable
Jefferson Davis	Moderate	Coastal influence
Lafayette	Moderate	Vermilion River, hit in 2016
Lafourche	Very High	Ida 2021 landfall, surge
LaSalle	Low-Moderate	Inland

Lincoln	Low	Inland, minimal
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Parish	Risk Level	Notes
Livingston	Very High	Ground zero in 2016
Madison	Moderate	Mississippi River basin
Morehouse	Moderate	Bayou risk
Natchitoches	Moderate	Cane and Red rivers
Orleans	Very High	Post-Katrina levees, varies block-to-block
Ouachita	Moderate	Ouachita River, Monroe area
Plaquemines	Very High	Highest premiums in LA, ~\$4,752/yr avg
Pointe Coupee	Moderate	False River, Mississippi
Rapides	Moderate	Red River, Alexandria
Red River	Moderate	Red River basin
Richland	Moderate	Boeuf River basin
Sabine	Low-Moderate	Sabine River and lake
St. Bernard	Very High	Devastated in Katrina, mostly SFHA
St. Charles	High	River and lake flooding
St. Helena	Moderate	Creek and river risk
St. James	High	River and basin
St. John the Baptist	High	LaPlace flooded in Ida
St. Landry	Moderate	Atchafalaya basin
St. Martin	High	Atchafalaya basin
St. Mary	Very High	Coastal, surge risk, Morgan City
St. Tammany	High	Lake Pontchartrain, river risk
Tangipahoa	High	Tangipahoa River, hit in 2016
Tensas	Moderate	Mississippi basin
Terrebonne	Very High	Coastal subsidence, surge
Union	Low-Moderate	Inland
Vermilion	High	Coastal influence
Vernon	Low-Moderate	Inland
Washington	Moderate	River and creek
Webster	Low-Moderate	Inland
West Baton Rouge	Moderate-High	River basin
West Carroll	Moderate	Bayou risk
West Feliciana	Moderate	River and bayou
Winn	Low-Moderate	Inland

Risk levels are general guides. Your actual rate depends on your specific zone, elevation, home value, and foundation type. For a real number, contact Brian.

10. Frequently Asked Questions

Do I have to have flood insurance?

Only if you have a federally-backed mortgage and live in a high-risk flood zone. But "have to" and "should" are different questions. About 25% of all flood claims come from outside high-risk zones.

How much does flood insurance cost in Louisiana?

The statewide median is around \$1,470/year. In low-risk zones with a Preferred Risk Policy, it can be as low as \$400-\$600/year. In high-risk coastal areas, it can exceed \$5,000/year.

Can renters get flood insurance?

Yes. NFIP offers contents-only policies for renters up to \$100,000. These usually cost under \$200/year.

What if my policy lapsed?

The 30-day waiting period kicks back in when you reinstate. If a flood happens during that gap, you have no coverage. Set up auto-pay to prevent lapses.

Can I switch flood insurance agents?

Yes. Transferring your existing flood policy to a new agent is free, takes minutes, and your coverage never lapses. Same policy, same price, same renewal date — just a different agent.

What is a Preferred Risk Policy (PRP)?

A discounted NFIP policy for properties in moderate-to-low risk zones (Zones X, B, C). Same federal coverage, lower premium. Often \$400-\$600/year.

Does flood insurance cover hurricane damage?

Flood insurance covers water damage from hurricanes — including storm surge. It does NOT cover wind damage. Wind is a separate windstorm or homeowners policy.

What is Risk Rating 2.0?

FEMA's pricing system rolled out in 2021-2023. Instead of just using flood zones, it factors in your specific property's distance to water, elevation, replacement cost, and foundation type. Rates went up significantly for many Louisiana homes.

Can I get flood insurance for a mobile home?

Yes, but rules are stricter. The home must be properly anchored to a permanent foundation and meet specific elevation requirements. NFIP covers mobile homes up to \$250,000.

What happens if I have a flood claim?

Document everything with photos and video before you touch anything. Then contact your flood insurance company immediately. An adjuster will be assigned. The process typically takes 30-90 days from filing to settlement.

Have Questions?

I answer my phone personally. I respond to emails the same day. I do free policy reviews with no obligation, and I'll tell you straight if your current coverage is solid — even if it means I don't get your business.

Louisiana flood insurance is too important to get wrong. If you have any questions after reading this guide, reach out.

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This guide is general information and not legal or financial advice. Insurance products and rates vary. Consult a licensed Louisiana insurance agent for advice specific to your situation.